

NRSP Safety Tip of The Week
By: Dovid Rosenberg

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Make sure to shovel out nearby fire hydrants after snowfall. Clear at least a 3-foot radius around the hydrant and a path to the street—this ensures firefighters can quickly locate and access it in an emergency, potentially saving minutes that could prevent a small fire from becoming catastrophic.

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COMMUNITY CORNER PARSHAS

YISRO יתרו

SHABBOS STARTS: **5:01 PM** (18 MINUTES)

SHABBOS ENDS: **6:10 PM** (50 MINUTES)

TZAIS HAKOCHAVIM: **6:31 PM** (72 MINUTES)

Editor-in-chief: Doni Stern
Made possible by contributing writers throughout our community.

STORY OF THE WEEK By: Zechariah Lipitz

A ripple of fear spread through the Jewish marketplace. "The wicked Haman is coming!" the merchants whispered as they hastily packed up their wares. Shutters were drawn and booths were closed. Buyers and sellers scattered like a flock of birds. Within minutes the marketplace was empty. No one had ever figured out why the town's commissar hated Jews so much, but such was the fact. He was always finding ways to make their lives miserable, imposing exorbitant taxes and confiscating their merchandise. Indeed, their appellation "the wicked Haman" was also an expression of hope that he too would meet the same end as the Biblical oppressor.

Reb Hillel was the town's local mohel. But given the oppressive atmosphere of those times, his work was carried out with the utmost secrecy. Quietly and unobtrusively, he would arrive at a Jewish home to bring a new baby into the covenant of Abraham. More than once it had been intimated that the authorities were aware of his activities. But Reb Hillel considered what he was doing a holy task and would not be deterred by the threat of punishment.

One day Reb Hillel found himself searching for an address in the wealthier section of town. He didn't know the name of the family whose infant he would be circumcising, but the neighborhood was exclusive to high-ranking government employees. Just that morning, the synagogue's attendant had given him the address.

When he found the house, the attendant was the only one there. "Seven more Jews will be arriving shortly," he was told. "Together with the baby's father we will have a minyan." One by one the others arrived, their faces etched with worry and caution. The only one missing was the father, who would be bringing the infant.

"Whose house is this?" Reb Hillel asked as they waited, but no one knew the answer. That morning, a well-dressed figure had suddenly approached the attendant as he was locking the synagogue's door and pushed a small piece of paper into his hand with the time and place of the brit mila. But everything else was a mystery.

However, there was no time for speculation, as at that moment the father walked in carrying the infant. The man was almost completely obscured by his heavy winter coat and hat, so it was very difficult to see what he looked like. Only Reb Hillel got a good glimpse as he took the baby from his arms. For some reason the man seemed familiar, but he couldn't quite place him. The brit was conducted quickly, and the father and infant left immediately afterward.

The next day Reb Hillel found a letter on his doorstep that caused his whole body to break out in gooseflesh. This was not the first time he was being summoned before the authorities, but he had a bad premonition. "No doubt my moment of truth has arrived," he fretted. When he reached the government building, he was immediately ushered into the office of the commissar. Reb Hillel's heartbeat wildly and his body trembled. And then it hit him: the dreaded commissar was the baby's father!

The commissar took a cigarette from a little wooden box on his desk and lit it. It was obvious that he was in an emotional state. "I could tell yesterday that you knew who I was," he began. "I called you here to make sure that no one else ever learns my identity." The commissar walked over to the window and then returned to his seat. Suddenly, without any prompting, he began to tell Reb Hillel his life story:

He had been born in a tiny, isolated village. His mother was a loving and caring person, but his father had been cruel and violent. At a young age he had run away from home. Three times he had regretted his action and written to his father but had never received an answer. As a result, he had become estranged from his Judaism and eventually abandoned it completely. For years he had held a grudge against the entire Jewish people. After serving in the army, he had continued to advance up the ranks to his present post. A few years ago, he had married a woman who, he discovered only after their marriage, was also Jewish. When it came time for her to deliver their first child, the labor was extremely difficult. Her life in danger, she had made her husband promise that if the baby was a boy and lived, he would undergo brit mila. The woman's life was spared, and the baby was indeed a boy.

"Yesterday," the commissar continued, "when I saw your willingness to endanger yourself for a total stranger, something moved in my heart. I can no longer justify my behavior toward the Jews."

The town's residents noticed the immediate change. It was truly inexplicable, but the commissar seemed to have run out of animosity. He even looked different as he walked through the marketplace, less arrogant and superior.

One Purim the news spread that the commissar had died suddenly. But instead of rejoicing, people merely shook their heads. A long time had passed since the days they had called him "the wicked Haman." But Reb Hillel was the only one who shed a tear.

PARSHA QUESTION By: Gavriel Grodko

I am normally invisible, yet the Bnei Yisroel saw me. What am I?

Stay tuned for the answer in the next Community Corner issue

Answer to last weeks parsha question:

- Q. In this Parsha, how did Hashem tell Moshe to extract water from a rock?
A. He was to speak to the rock with his staff in hand.

TEFILLAH OF THE WEEK

הללוה - Hallelukah #5

Praise God. Praise the Almighty in His Sanctuary
-Praise God in the firmament of His might
-Praise Him for His mighty deeds
-Praise Him according to the abundance of His greatness
-Praise Him with the blowing of the shofar
-praise Him with lyre and harp
-Praise Him with drum and dance
-Praise Him with stringed instruments and flute
-Praise Him with resounding cymbals
-Praise Him with clanging cymbals
-Let every soul praise God. Praise God
-Let every soul praise God. Praise God

THIS WEEK IN JEWISH HISTORY By: Avi Hirsch

Haym Salomon (also Solomon; April 7, 1740 – January 6, 1785) was a Polish-born American merchant best known for his actions during the American Revolution, where he was one of the prime financiers to the Continental Congress.

Born in Leszno, Polish-Lithuanian Commonwealth, Salomon studied finance in Western Europe before emigrating to New York City in 1775. After the American Revolutionary War broke out in the same year, Salomon supported the Patriots by providing financial services while working alongside financier Robert Morris, the Superintendent of Finance of the United States, and risked his life as a member of the Sons of Liberty, leading to multiple arrests by the British for espionage. He helped convert French loans into hard currency by selling bills of exchange on Morris' behalf and Iso brokered large donations to the Patriot cause. This included a critical \$20,000 loan in 1781 that enabled George Washington's decisive Yorktown campaign, a turning point for American independence. From 1781 to 1784, Salomon helped provide over \$650,000 (\$14.8 million in 2024). He was also an advocate for religious liberty by co-founding Philadelphia's Mikveh Israel synagogue and challenging discriminatory laws. Despite donating his entire fortune to the Continental Army and several Founding Fathers of the United States, Salomon died penniless in Philadelphia in 1785 due to the failure of government officials and private lenders to repay the debt they owed to him.

In August 1781, the Continental Army trapped Lieutenant General Charles Cornwallis in the Virginia coastal town of Yorktown. George Washington and the main army, and Count de Rochambeau with his French army, decided to march from the Hudson Highlands to Yorktown and deliver the final blow. But Washington's war chest was completely empty, as was that of Congress. Without food, uniforms and supplies, Washington's troops were close to mutiny. Washington determined that he needed at least \$20,000 to finance the campaign. When Morris told him there were no funds and no credit available, Washington said: "Send for Haym Salomon". Salomon raised \$20,000, through the sale of bills of exchange. With that contribution, Washington conducted the Yorktown campaign, which proved to be the final battle of the Revolution.

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